



Department
of Health

CHILDREN'S CAMPS SWIMMING SAFETY

Recreational Environmental Health Section
Bureau of Community Environmental Health and Food Protection

Spring 2026



OVERVIEW

- 2025 Season Swimming Incidents
- Multiple Barrier Approach to Safe Swimming
- Resources

CHILDREN'S CAMPS SWIMMING INCIDENTS

- 5 non-fatal drownings associated with children's camps swimming were reported during the 2025 season

Date	Camper Age	Setting
June 2025	5	On-site outdoor public pool used by camp
	4	Camp's bathing beach
July 2025	3	Camp's outdoor pool, during swim lessons
August 2025	5	Camp trip to State Park outdoor pool (camp operating without a permit)
	4	Camp trip to water park – outdoor wave pool (camp operating without a permit)

- Drowning happens when a person cannot breathe because their nose and mouth are submerged in water, and their body does not get enough oxygen
 - A fatal drowning means the drowning victim died
 - A non-fatal drowning means the drowning victim survived



CONTRIBUTING FACTORS IDENTIFIED (PRELIMINARY)

Camp swimming requirements

- No safety plan
- Failure to implement approved safety plan
- No assessment of camper swimming ability
- Buddies not documented/no buddy board
- No buddy checks
- No visual identification of non-swimmers
- Non-swimmers not restricted to water less than chest deep
- Counselors providing inadequate or no supervision
- Failure to provide 1 to 3 ratio of counselors to non swimmers in water greater than chest deep

Bather supervision

- Inadequate number of lifeguards
- Chair change at time of incident
- Inadequate scanning techniques
- Lifeguard positioning

Environmental

- Poor water clarity

Victim

- All young children 3 to 5 years of age
- All non-swimmers or ability not assessed

AQUATIC SAFETY AT CHILDREN'S CAMPS

**NOT JUST HORNS, BELLS,
& WHISTLES!**



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https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IsFx_TvXJOA

MULTIPLE BARRIER APPROACH

- **Camper Supervision:** Aquatics Director, Lifeguards, Counselors
- **Camper Swimming Ability:**
 - Assessed by progressive swimming instructor
 - Water depth restricted for non-swimmers/designated swimming areas
 - Visually identify non-swimmers
- **Camper Accountability:** Buddy System, Board System, buddy checks at least every 15 minutes
- **Additional requirements** for off-site swimming, wilderness swimming
- **Camp's written safety plan** describes how the camp will accomplish the above

SUPERVISION



QUALIFIED
AQUATICS
DIRECTOR



LIFEGUARDS



COUNSELORS
– ACTIVELY
SUPERVISING
ASSIGNED
CAMPERS



PERFORM
BUDDY
CHECKS



BATHER
CHECK
IN/OUT



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SWIMMING ASSESSMENT

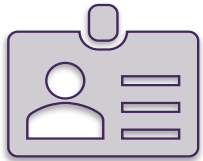
- Assess swimming abilities for each camper
 - Determined by a progressive swim instructor (PSI)
 - Conducted annually and as appropriate
 - Campers considered non-swimmers until determined otherwise by PSI
- Minimum of two bather classifications
 - Non-swimmer and swimmer
- Assessment criteria is not specified in Subpart 7-2
 - Suggested criteria is included in the safety plan template

NON-SWIMMER WATER DEPTH RESTRICTION AND VISUAL IDENTIFICATION



Restrict non-swimmers to water less than chest deep, except:

- During approved learn to swim programs
- When 1:3 in-water supervision is provided: a counselor in the water directly supervises a maximum of three non-swimmers in shallow water in the non-swimmer area



Visual identification:

- Identify swimmers, or both swimmers and non-swimmers



Rationale:

- Bathers become buoyant in water chest deep and above which causes them to lose contact with the bottom
- Non-swimmers who lose contact with the bottom may not have the ability to prevent themselves from entering deeper water

DESIGNATION OF SWIMMING AREAS

Non-swimmers in water less than chest deep

Designate areas: float lines, staff positioning, separate pools, docks

Natural bodies of water may have depth fluctuations

Surf beach and wave pool (not appropriate for non-swimmers)

Some pools may be too deep for shortest non-swimmer

BUDDY SYSTEM

Tags	Camp Fun – Buddy Board									
Cabin 1	Non-Swimmer Area					Swimmer Area				
Cabin 2	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●
Cabin 3	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●
Cabin 4	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●
Beach	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	Restroom				

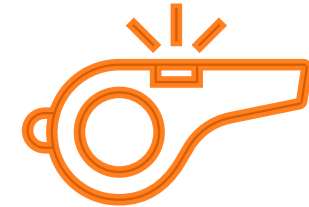
Assign each bather to a buddy

- Pair same swimming abilities
- If a non-swimmer is paired with a swimmer, both must remain in the non-swimmer area
- One trio is allowed per swim area



Buddies must be instructed to:

- Notify lifeguards/ counselors when their partner is in distress or missing
- Stay near their buddy



Conduct buddy checks:

- At beginning, end, and at least every 15 minutes during each swim session
- Reference checks against board/ accountability system
- On average shouldn't take longer than a minute

BOARD SYSTEM (OR EQUIVALENT ACCOUNTABILITY SYSTEM)

- A method of recording entry and exit from the pool/beach areas including:
 - Swimming areas
 - Pool/beach enclosure
- Board system identifies each bather by:
 - Full name
 - Swimming ability
 - Area the bather is assigned to
- Should identify buddy pairs and trios

SAFETY PLAN



An operational and risk management manual



Addresses camp-specific aspects of aquatics programming

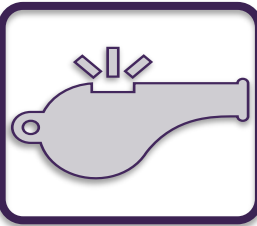


Interactive Templates

- ✓ Personnel roles & responsibilities
- ✓ Facility characteristics & designated swimming areas
- ✓ Supervision
- ✓ Safety equipment
- ✓ Swimming assessments
- ✓ Rules & regulations
- ✓ Lost Bather Plan
- ✓ Buddy & board systems
- ✓ Camp trip swimming or wilderness swimming where applicable

CAMP TRIPS AND SWIMMING AT POOLS/BEACHES OPEN TO THE PUBLIC

Unique Challenges:



Signaling buddy
checks



Campers interacting
with public



Facility staff versus
camp staff

CAMP TRIPS AND SWIMMING AT POOLS/BEACHES OPEN TO THE PUBLIC

- Overcoming challenges:
 - When possible, dedicate a section of the aquatic facility to just the camp
 - Prearrangements and open communication between aquatic and camp managers
 - Determine how/if aquatic staff are integrated into camp swimming activity
 - Signal and procedures for buddy checks
 - Staff and camper orientation/training

RESOURCES

health.ny.gov/camps



- Safety Plan Templates:
 - [On-site swimming](#)
 - [Off-site and wilderness swimming](#)
- Fact Sheets/Publications:
 - [Swimming Requirements](#)
 - [Wilderness Swimming](#)
 - [Supervision of Boating Activities](#)
 - [Requirements for Children's Camps in New York State](#)

- Certification Fact Sheets:
 - [Camp Aquatics Director](#)
 - [Lifeguard](#)
 - [Camp Trip Swimming](#)
 - [Progressive Swimming Instructor](#)
 - [Learn-to-Swim Programs](#)
- [Subpart 7-2 Children's Camps](#)
- [Your Local Health Department!](#)



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Thank you!



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health.ny.gov/environmentalcontacts